Philemon 8–19 — Leader / Learner Guide

A Comprehensive Appeal · a one-page guide for leaders and learners

The Epistle to Philemon · TheGospelVault.com · @iJohn.316 (Instagram)

① Big Idea and Context

Big idea: Paul, now the soul of tact, does not command Philemon but appeals along three lines — necessity, responsibility, and liability — to receive Onesimus as a beloved brother, as he would Paul, with Paul paying whatever is owed.

"A man who would have friends must himself be friendly" (Prov. 18:24). Paul had his moments with Barnabas and John Mark, but he learned; here he is walking on eggshells.

- **Necessity (vv. 8–13):** Paul gives his rights, then gives them up for higher ground, gains, and goals.
- **Responsibility (vv. 14–17):** Paul's, Onesimus', and Philemon's — no longer a slave, more than a slave, as Paul himself.
- **Liability (vv. 18–19):** "Put that on my account" — a picture of imputation.

② Put It on My Account — Three Anchor Verses

Verse	What it says	Teaching point
v. 9	*"yet for love's sake I rather appeal to you"*	Paul could command as an apostle; he appeals as "Paul the aged" and a prisoner of Jesus Christ.
v. 11	*"once … unprofitable … but now is profitable"*	Paronomasia: Onesimus means "useful"; *achrēstos* → *euchrēstos*.
v. 18	*"put that on my account"*	A non-theological picture of imputation: Christ paid a debt He did not owe (2 Cor. 5:21).

Negative, positive, superlative (vv. 16–17): no longer a slave · more than a slave, a beloved brother · receive him as you would me.

Iron fist, velvet glove (v. 19b): "not to mention … you owe me even your own self besides."

③ Teaching Flow

1. **Introduction.** Proverbs 18:24; Paul, Barnabas, and John Mark (Acts 15:36; Col. 4:10; 1 Cor. 9:6).
2. **Necessity (vv. 8–13).** Rights given, then given up — higher ground, higher gains (son, slave), higher goals.
3. **Responsibility (vv. 14–17).** Voluntary, not by compulsion; a changed life; receive him as a brother, as Paul.
4. **Liability (vv. 18–19).** The debit side ("put it on my account") and the credit side ("you owe me … your own self").
5. **Conclusion.** Paul appealed rather than demanded — and they were friends. A friend who sticks closer than a brother.

④ Clarify While Teaching

- **1 Corinthians 9:6:** the sermon as preached says "who have the right"; the text reads "who have no right to refrain from working."
- **Paul's age:** 57 now and 62 at death are the sermon's estimates; Scripture does not give Paul's age.
- **"My son":** Paul also calls Timothy and Titus his sons (1 Tim. 1:2; Titus 1:4), more than twice in all.
- **"Aged" (v. 9):** NKJV reads "aged"; some scholars read "ambassador." The sermon follows "aged."

⑤ Discussion and Close

1. Where are you tempted to use your rights instead of making an appeal for love's sake?
2. Who is the "Onesimus" in your life — someone you need to receive as a brother or sister?
3. How is v. 18 a picture of what Christ did for us?

Close: Point ahead to vv. 20–25, "A Compelling Appendix": Paul expects Philemon to do even more than he asks. "I owed a debt I could not pay; He paid a debt He did not owe."

Full study: A Comprehensive Appeal — Philemon 8–19 · Source: The Gospel Vault